

doc-imputed-righteousness

Affirms · Soteriology › Justification · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

In justification, the believer is reckoned righteous before God on the basis of Christ's work received by faith, not on the basis of righteousness inherent in the believer.

Rationale

The canonical lexical pattern is unambiguous: God reckons righteousness to the believer through faith in Christ, not on the basis of works performed by the believer. Gen 15:6 (הֵקֵדַצְוָה יְהוָה בְּאֵימַן וְחִשְׁבָהּ לֵהּ צְדָקָה, 'vehe'emin baYHWH vayyachshveha lo tsedaqah, 'and he believed in YHWH and he counted it to him as righteousness'; chashav H2803 Qal wayyiqtol, the bookkeeping verb of crediting; tsedaqah H6666) is the seed text. Rom 4:3-8 quotes Gen 15:6 (logizomai G3049 + eis dikaiosynen) and presses the verb across multiple verses (vv. 3, 5, 6, 8, 9, 10, 11, 22, 23, 24), defining the term against erga ('works', v.5) and against the unreckoning of sin (v.8, ou me logisetai Kyrios hamartian, citing Ps 32:1-2). Rom 5:17 names this as he dorea tes dikaiosynes ('the gift of righteousness', dorea G1431, received, not earned). Rom 5:19 (dia tes hypakoes tou henos dikaiou katastathesontai hoi polloi, 'through the obedience of the one the many will be constituted righteous'; kathistemi G2525 future passive). 2 Cor 5:21 (ton me gnonta hamartian hyper hemon hamartian epoiesen, hina hemeis genometha dikaiosyne theou en autoi, 'him who knew no sin he made to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God') sets a substitutionary exchange. Phil 3:9 contrasts emen dikaiosynen ten ek nomou ('my own righteousness from law') with ten dia pisteos Christou, ten ek theou dikaiosynen ('the righteousness through faith in Christ, the righteousness from God'); ek theou marks the source as outside the believer. Jer 23:6 names the Messianic king YHWH Tsidkenu (וְיִקְרָא יְהוָה צִדְקֵנוּ; 'YHWH our righteousness'), placing the believer's righteousness in a person external to the believer. The pan-canonical lexical reading sustains the basic proposition. The precise forensic-only versus transformative-infused mechanism is in-house Christian disagreement and does NOT itself rise to cult-marker level.

Reasoning

Verdict: The believer's right standing before God rests on what Jesus Christ has done, received by faith, not on the believer's own good works or moral performance. The strongest reason from Scripture is the way the Bible repeatedly describes God 'counting' or 'crediting' righteousness to someone who believes. Genesis 15:6 says of Abraham, 'he believed the LORD, and the LORD counted it to him as righteousness.' Paul picks up this same word, 'counted,' all through Romans 4. In Romans 4:5 he writes that to the one who does not work but trusts God, 'his faith is counted as righteousness.' In Romans 4:8 he quotes Psalm 32 to say 'blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.' Second Corinthians 5:21 makes the exchange explicit: God 'made him who knew no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.' Philippians 3:9 contrasts Paul's own righteousness from following the law with 'the righteousness from God that depends on faith.' The strongest counterargument from Scripture is James 2:21 to 24, which says Abraham was justified by works when he offered Isaac, and that a person is justified by works and not by faith alone. James and Paul use the same Genesis 15:6 quote but seem to point opposite directions. The standard handling is that Paul addresses how a sinner first gets right with God, where works cannot earn anything, while James addresses how genuine faith proves itself real, where a faith that produces no fruit is a dead faith and not saving faith. Romans 5 and Galatians 5 affirm both, that justification is by faith alone and that real faith works through love. The lay reader should know: most of historic Christianity, including Catholic, Orthodox, Lutheran, Reformed, Anglican, Methodist, Anabaptist, and Pentecostal traditions, affirms that the believer's right standing is grounded in Christ, not in

the believer's own works. Where they disagree is the precise mechanism. The Reformed and Lutheran traditions describe it as God crediting Christ's righteousness to the believer's account while the believer remains imperfect. The Catholic tradition describes it as God actually pouring righteousness into the believer, transforming the heart. The Orthodox tradition describes salvation as participation in God's own life rather than a courtroom transaction. The 1999 Joint Declaration between the Catholic Church and the Lutheran World Federation reached agreement that these are complementary descriptions of one reality. The proposition as worded reflects the Reformed framing specifically, which is one valid Christian description but not the only one.

Denominational landscape

All historic Christian traditions affirm the underlying gospel proposition that the believer's right standing before God is grounded in Christ rather than in the believer's own works. The disagreement is about the precise mechanism. The patristic period (Augustine, Chrysostom, Athanasius) used a range of language: Augustine often speaks of God's gracious gift of righteousness through faith without using the precise later Reformed forensic vocabulary. The Catholic Church at the Council of Trent in 1547 explicitly rejected forensic-only imputation in favor of infused righteousness, teaching that justification involves both the remission of sins and the interior sanctification and renewal of the person. The Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 1987 to 1995 maintains this: 'Justification is not only the remission of sins, but also the sanctification and renewal of the interior man,' with grace, faith, hope, and charity poured into the heart. Lutheran teaching, in the Formula of Concord Article III, affirms the Reformed forensic position: God 'imputes to us the righteousness of Christ's obedience, on account of which righteousness we are received into grace by God, and regarded as righteous.' The Anglican 39 Articles, Article 11, says 'we are accounted righteous before God, only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ by Faith, and not for our own works or deservings.' Reformed confessions (Westminster 11.1-3, Heidelberg Q60-61, Belgic 22-23) systematize this same forensic framework. Methodism, in Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles (Article 9), repeats the Anglican formula on imputation but Wesleyan teaching adds heavy emphasis on imparted righteousness in sanctification, where God actually transforms the believer. Anabaptist confessions (Schleitheim, Dordrecht) focus more on discipleship than on the precise mechanism of justification. Pentecostalism (Assemblies of God) affirms justification by faith without taking sides between forensic and infused. Eastern Orthodoxy considers the entire Reformation justification debate to be a Western legal-courtroom framing of what they describe as theosis, the believer's participation in the divine life through union with Christ. The 1999 Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification, signed by the Catholic Church and the Lutheran World Federation and later affirmed by the Methodist and Reformed World Communions, reached qualified ecumenical agreement that imputation language and infusion language describe complementary aspects of one reality. Public-record carriers of denial of the underlying gospel proposition (that the believer's standing is grounded in Christ rather than in the believer's own works) include Mormonism (exaltation requires personal righteousness plus temple ordinances), Iglesia ni Cristo (salvation through church membership), Jehovah's Witnesses (door-to-door witnessing work as part of justification), and historic Pelagianism (condemned at the Council of Carthage in 418). The narrower disagreement about the precise mechanism of imputation versus infusion is in-house Christian disagreement and does not place either side outside historic Christianity.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes

Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Two layers must be separated. Layer one is the canonical lexical core: the believer's right standing before God is grounded in Christ's work received by faith, not in the believer's own works. This is affirmed across every historic Christian lineage (Catholic, Orthodox, Lutheran, Reformed, Anglican, Methodist, Anabaptist, Pentecostal), is grounded in pan-canonical Hebrew chashav and Greek logizomai usage, and would_die_for is true on this layer. Layer two is the precise mechanism: Reformed and Lutheran confessions (Westminster 11.1-3; Formula of Concord Epitome III; 39 Articles 11) teach forensic imputation, that Christ's righteousness is reckoned to the believer's account while the believer remains intrinsically sinful (simul iustus et peccator). Catholic Council of Trent Session 6 (1547) and the post-Tridentine Catechism (CCC 1989-1995) teach that justification involves an interior infusion of righteousness (sanctification and renewal of the interior man), rejecting forensic-only language. Eastern Orthodoxy treats the entire Reformation justification debate as a Western legal-judicial framing of what they understand as theosis, participation in divine life. Wesleyan-Methodism (Article 9) affirms 'accounted righteous before God for the merit of Christ by faith' but adds Wesleyan stress on imparted righteousness in sanctification. The 1999 Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification (Catholic plus Lutheran World Federation) reached qualified ecumenical agreement that imputation and infusion describe complementary aspects of one reality. Public-record carriers of significant in-house re-framing include the New Perspective on Paul writers (E. P. Sanders, James Dunn, N. T. Wright) who read Pauline dikaiosyne as covenantal membership rather than as transferred merit, and the Federal Vision writers who blur the imputation-infusion line. None of these in-house Catholic, Orthodox, Wesleyan, New Perspective positions denies the basic gospel proposition that the believer's standing is grounded in Christ rather than in the believer's works. The cult-marker line therefore falls below the precise mechanism. Public-record carriers of denial of the GOSPEL itself (works-righteousness without Christ, salvation by personal merit, denial that Christ's work is the ground of acceptance) include Mormonism (exaltation by ordinances plus personal righteousness), Iglesia ni Cristo (church-membership soteriology where the church itself is the saving instrument), Jehovah's Witnesses (door-to-door witness work as part of justification), and historic Pelagianism (condemned at the Council of Carthage AD 418). Denial of the basic proposition that righteous standing is grounded in Christ would warrant cult-marker. Denial of the narrower Reformed forensic mechanism alone does not. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: a Catholic who trusts Christ for salvation while affirming infused righteousness still rests on Christ's work, not on personal merit; a Reformed believer who trusts Christ for salvation while affirming forensic imputation rests on the same person. The lived faith converges; the systematic framing diverges. Public-record evangelical critics of the New Perspective on Paul (John Piper, D. A. Carson) argue the Reformed forensic framing is necessary; New Perspective writers reply that Paul's logizomai is covenant-incorporation language. Both sides cite canonical text. The question itself, as worded, encodes the Reformed framing as if neutral, which the stem audit flags.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. The believer's right standing before God is grounded in Christ's work received by faith, not in righteousness produced by the believer's own works.

Notes. The original statement uses Reformed-Protestant-confessional vocabulary: 'reckoned righteous' (forensic-imputation language), and the explicit contrast 'not on the basis of righteousness inherent in the believer' (the precise Reformed denial of the Catholic and Orthodox infused-righteousness position). The stem assumes the Reformed forensic framing as if it were the only Christian option. Catholic teaching (Council of Trent Session 6; CCC 1989-1995), Eastern Orthodox theology, and Wesleyan teaching all affirm that the believer's right standing is grounded in Christ rather than in the believer's own works, while rejecting forensic-only formulations. The neutralized form preserves what is pan-canonically supported (the believer's standing rests on Christ, not on the believer's own works) while dropping the precise forensic-versus-infused mechanism, which is genuine in-house Christian disagreement. Flag stem-pre-loaded-verdict applied.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. reformation_forensic_imputation, tridentine_infused_righteousness, orthodox_theosis, wesleyan_imparted_righteousness, new_perspective_on_paul, covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

- **affirms:**
- affirms_with_qualification:
- affirms_with_qualification:
- affirms_with_qualification:
- affirms_with_qualification:
- **affirms:**

Verdict requires honest separation of two layers. Layer one, the underlying gospel proposition (the believer's right standing rests on Christ, received by faith, not on works of the believer), is pan-canonically supported by logizomai G3049 (Gen 15:6, Rom 4, Gal 3:6, Jas 2:23) and dorea G1431 (Rom 5:17) and dōron G1435 (Eph 2:8), and is affirmed across every historic Christian lineage. Layer two, the precise mechanism (forensic imputation versus infused righteousness versus theosis versus imparted righteousness), is genuinely contested in-house among Catholic, Orthodox, Lutheran, Reformed, and Wesleyan readings of the same texts. The proposition as worded encodes the Reformed framing as if neutral, which the stem audit flagged. Analogia scripturae is invoked at the Pauline-Jamesian tension (Rom 3:28 versus Jas 2:24), resolved by two-frame reading (justification before God versus vindication before observers). Progressive revelation operates from Gen 15:6 (the seed) through Isa 53 and Jer 23:6 (prophetic clarification) to Rom 4 and 2 Cor 5:21 (apostolic exposition)

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Gen.15.6 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. אָמָן H539 Hiphil perfect; חָשַׁב H2803 Qal wayyiqtol; tsedaqah H6666

Force. 'And he believed in YHWH, and he counted it to him as righteousness.' Chashav is the standard Hebrew bookkeeping or accounting verb: to think, calculate, reckon, credit. The verb takes faith as object and tsedaqah as the credited result. Faith itself is what is reckoned as the standing, not works performed. The wayyiqtol form fits the narrative-consequence sequence: belief led to the divine reckoning. Paul cites this verse three times (Rom 4:3, Gal 3:6, Rom 4:22-23) as the load-bearing foundation of his doctrine of justification by faith

Rom.4.3 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐπίστευσεν δὲ Ἀβραὰμ τῷ θεῷ καὶ ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; pisteuo G4100 aorist active indicative 3s; logizomai G3049 aorist passive indicative 3s; dikaiosyne G1343

Force. 'Abraham believed God, and it was reckoned to him as righteousness.' Direct citation of Gen 15:6 LXX. Logizomai G3049 is the LXX rendering of chashav: the same bookkeeping verb. The aorist passive elogisthe ('it was reckoned') with the divine implicit agent (a divine passive). Faith stands as that which is credited, with righteousness as the standing credited. The construction logizomai eis dikaiosynen will be repeated by Paul throughout the chapter (vv. 3, 5, 9, 10, 22, 23, 24) as the controlling phrase

Rom.4.5 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. τῷ δὲ μὴ ἐργαζομένῳ πιστεύοντι δὲ ἐπὶ τὸν δικαιοῦντα τὸν ἀσεβῆ λογίζεται ἡ πίστις αὐτοῦ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; ergazomai G2038 present middle participle; dikaiouo G1344 present active participle; asebes G765; logizomai G3049 present passive indicative 3s

Force. 'But to the one who does not work but trusts him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness.' Sharp contrast between erga (works performed) and pistis (faith) as the basis of the reckoning. God is described as the one who justifies (dikaioo) the asebes ('ungodly', 'impious'), which forbids reading righteousness as inherent in the recipient at the moment of justification. The construction logizomai eis dikaiosynen of v.3 is repeated, this time with present passive logizetai, marking the reckoning as ongoing in Paul's gospel pattern, not limited to Abraham

Rom.4.6 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. λέγει τὸν μακαρισμὸν τοῦ ἀνθρώπου ὃ ὁ θεὸς λογίζεται δικαιοσύνην χωρὶς ἔργων; logizomai G3049 present middle indicative 3s; chōris G5565; ergon G2041

Force. 'David also speaks of the blessing of the one to whom God counts righteousness apart from works.' The phrase chōris ergon ('apart from works') is the controlling qualifier: the reckoning of righteousness happens independently of works performed. Citation of Ps 32:1-2 follows. David is offered as a second witness alongside Abraham, showing this is not an isolated patriarchal pattern but the standard divine accounting toward those who trust God

Rom.4.8 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. μακάριος ἀνὴρ οὗ οὐ μὴ λογίσῃται Κύριος ἁμαρτίαν; logizomai G3049 aorist middle subjunctive 3s with ou me; hamartia G266

Force. 'Blessed is the man whose sin the Lord will not count against him.' The double negative ou me with the aorist subjunctive of logizomai is the strongest Greek negation: the Lord will absolutely not reckon sin against the blessed person. Quoting Ps 32:2 LXX. The non-reckoning of sin (v.8) is the negative counterpart of the reckoning of righteousness (vv.3, 5, 6). Together they sketch the divine bookkeeping pattern: faith credited as righteousness, sin not credited as debt

Rom.4.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. διὸ καὶ ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; logizomai G3049 aorist passive indicative 3s

Force. 'That is why his faith was counted to him as righteousness.' Paul returns to the Gen 15:6 citation as the climactic anchor of his argument, this time tying the reckoning explicitly to the content of Abraham's faith (he believed God could give life to the dead and call into being what was not, vv. 17-21). The structural inclusion (v.3 to v.22) frames the chapter

Rom.4.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐκ ἐγράφη δὲ δι' αὐτὸν μόνον ὅτι ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ ἀλλὰ καὶ δι' ἡμᾶς οἷς μέλλει λογίζεσθαι; mellō G3195 present active indicative 3s with infinitive of logizomai G3049

Force. 'But the words it was counted to him were not written for his sake alone, but for ours also. It will be counted to us who believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord.' Paul extends the Abrahamic pattern to all who believe in the God who raised Jesus. The construction mellei logizesthai (future of logizomai) tells the Roman believers and every subsequent reader that this same reckoning is on offer to them on the same faith terms

Rom.5.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τὴν περισσείαν τῆς χάριτος καὶ τῆς δωρεᾶς τῆς δικαιοσύνης λαμβάνοντες ἐν ζωῇ βασιλεύσουσιν; dorea G1431; lambanō G2983 present active participle; dikaiosyne G1343

Force. 'Those who receive the abundance of grace and the free gift of righteousness will reign in life through the one man Jesus Christ.' Dorea G1431 ('free gift') is the standard Greek term for what is given without exchange, not earned. Righteousness here is something received (lambanontes, present active participle of lambano), not generated. The phrase he dorea tes dikaiosynes ('the gift of righteousness') is a strong lexical anchor: the righteousness is given, not produced from within

Rom.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. διὰ τῆς ὑπακοῆς τοῦ ἐνὸς δίκαιοι κατασταθήσονται οἱ πολλοί; hypakoē G5218; dikaios G1342; kathistemi G2525 future passive indicative 3p

Force. 'By the one man's obedience the many will be constituted righteous.' Kathistemi G2525 ('to constitute, establish, set down as') in the future passive: the many will be set down by God as righteous on the basis of the obedience of the one (Christ). The structural parallel of v.19 (Adam's disobedience constituting the many as sinners; Christ's obedience constituting the many as righteous) shows the same kind of representative-imputation logic operating on both sides. The basis of the constituting is Christ's obedience, not the obedience of the many

2Cor.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τὸν μὴ γνόντα ἁμαρτίαν ὑπὲρ ἡμῶν ἁμαρτίαν ἐποίησεν ἵνα ἡμεῖς γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ; ginōskō G1097 aorist active participle with negation; hamartia G266; poieō G4160 aorist active indicative; ginomai G1096 aorist subjunctive 1p; dikaiosyne G1343; theos G2316

Force. 'He made him who knew no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.' Two parallel non-natural attributions: Christ who knew no sin was made (epoiesen) to be sin, and we (who have sinned) become (genometha) the righteousness of God. Both are non-inherent attributions: Christ does not become intrinsically sinful, and the believers do not become intrinsically perfect at the moment of justification. The framing en autoi ('in him') marks union with Christ as the location of the exchange. Hyper hemon ('for us') marks the substitutionary structure

Phil.3.9 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ ἔχων ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην τὴν ἐκ νόμου ἀλλὰ τὴν διὰ πίστεως Χριστοῦ τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει; dikaiosyne G1343; emos G1699; ek G1537; nomos G3551; pistis G4102; theos G2316

Force. 'Not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which comes through faith in Christ, the righteousness from God that depends on faith.' Sharp three-way contrast: *emen dikaiosynen ten ek nomou* (mine, from law) versus *dikaosynen ek theou* (from God) versus *epi te pistei* (on the basis of faith) and *dia pisteos Christou* (through faith in Christ). The dual *ek* phrases (*ek nomou* rejected, *ek theou* received) mark the source of righteousness as outside the believer. Paul, who under Phil 3:4-6 reckoned himself blameless under the law, repudiates his own righteousness as a basis of standing

Jer.23.6 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. וְנִקְרָא הוּא יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְנִשְׁמָע בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה; YHWH H3068; tsedeq H6664 with first person common plural suffix

Force. 'And this is the name by which he will be called: YHWH our righteousness.' The Messianic king (the righteous Branch of v.5) bears the name YHWH Tsidkenu. The construct form with first person plural suffix locates the righteousness in him as belonging to us: it is OUR righteousness, but the righteousness IS the LORD himself. Old Testament canonical witness that the source of the believer's righteousness is a person external to the believer, foreshadowing the New Testament pattern of righteousness in Christ

Jer.33.16 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. וְנִקְרָא הוּא יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְנִשְׁמָע בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה; YHWH H3068; tsedeq H6664

Force. 'And this is the name by which she will be called: YHWH our righteousness.' Parallel anchor to Jer 23:6, this time applied to Jerusalem (the city restored under the Messianic king). The repetition of YHWH Tsidkenu confirms it as a fixed prophetic title: the LORD himself is the source of the righteousness of the restored covenant community

Isa.61.10 · **for** · genre: prophecy · figures: metaphor

Key term. וְנִשְׂמָע בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְנִקְרָא הוּא יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ; labash H3847 Hiphil perfect; beged H899; yesha H3468; meil H4598; tsedaqah H6666; atah H5844

Force. 'For he has clothed me with the garments of salvation; he has covered me with the robe of righteousness.' The clothing metaphor (Hiphil of labash, He has caused me to be clothed) describes righteousness as given to and wrapped around the recipient, not generated from within. The garments-of-salvation, robe-of-righteousness imagery is the OT background for the NT clothing-with-Christ language (Rom 13:14, Gal 3:27)

Isa.64.6 · **for** · genre: prophecy · figures: metaphor, hyperbole

Key term. וְנִשְׂמָע בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְנִקְרָא הוּא יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ; tame H2931; beged H899; ed H5708; tsedaqah H6666 plural construct with first person plural suffix

Force. 'We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteousnesses are like a polluted garment.' Israel's collective confession: even our righteousnesses (*tsidqotenu*, plural construct) are like a defiled cloth before God. Negative anchor: human righteousness, even at its best, cannot ground standing before YHWH. Combined with Isa 61:10 (the robe of righteousness given by God), the prophetic witness sets up the substitutionary pattern of the NT

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τῇ γὰρ χάριτί ἐστε σεσωσμένοι διὰ πίστεως καὶ τοῦτο οὐκ ἐξ ὑμῶν θεοῦ τὸ δῶρον οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων; charis G5485; sōzō G4982 perfect passive participle; pistis G4102; dōron G1435; ergon G2041

Force. 'For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.' Doron G1435 ('gift') is parallel to dorea G1431 in Rom 5:17; both mark the divine giving of salvation/righteousness as without exchange. The threefold construction (charis as means, pistis as instrument, ouk ex ergon as exclusion) parallels the Romans 4 logic and rules out works performed by the believer as the ground of acceptance

Gal.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. καθὼς Ἀβραὰμ ἐπίστευσεν τῷ θεῷ καὶ ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; pisteuo G4100; logizomai G3049 aorist passive

Force. 'Just as Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.' Third Pauline citation of Gen 15:6 (also Rom 4:3, 4:22), this time as the load-bearing premise of the Galatian argument that the Galatian believers, like Abraham, are justified by faith and not by works of the law. The cross-canonical anchor (Gen 15:6, Rom 4, Gal 3, Jas 2) shows logizomai eis dikaiosynen as a structural pattern, not a single-passage construction

Jas.2.23 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐπίστευσεν δὲ Ἀβραὰμ τῷ θεῷ καὶ ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; logizomai G3049; ergon G2041; dikaios G1344

Force. 'Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness; and he was called a friend of God.' James cites the same Gen 15:6 verse Paul cites, in the same Greek wording, but applies it as proof that genuine faith works (vv.21-26). The apparent tension with Paul resolves on two-step reading: Paul addresses how a sinner first gets right with God (justification before God on the basis of Christ's work received by faith, where works contribute nothing); James addresses how a confessing person proves the faith real before others (the works-vindication, where a faith that produces no fruit is dead and so is not the saving kind). Both use logizomai eis dikaiosynen of Gen 15:6 as the bedrock

Jas.2.24 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁρᾶτε ὅτι ἐξ ἔργων δικαιοῦται ἄνθρωπος καὶ οὐκ ἐκ πίστεως μόνον; dikaios G1344 present passive indicative 3s; ek ergon; pistis monon

Force. 'You see that a person is justified by works and not by faith alone.' The only NT verse to use pistis monon ('faith alone'), and it negates it in the works-vindication frame. Read with Rom 3:28 (Paul: 'we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law'), the apparent contradiction is resolved by recognising two distinct framings: Paul's dikaios describes God's verdict on the sinner (the courtroom; the question is how a guilty defendant stands); James's dikaios describes the vindication of confession before observers (the witness stand; the question is whether the claimed faith is the real kind). Genuine in-house tension in the precise framing; not a denial of grace-grounded standing

Rom.3.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. λογιζόμεθα γὰρ δικαιοῦσθαι πίστει ἄνθρωπον χωρὶς ἔργων νόμου; logizomai G3049 present middle indicative 1p; dikaios G1344 present passive infinitive; pistis G4102; ergon G2041; nomos G3551

Force. 'For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law.' The headline Pauline statement, using the same logizomai verb of Paul's own conclusion: WE reckon that justification is by faith chōris ergon nomou ('apart from works of law'). Frames the controlling Pauline position on which the Romans 4 exposition rests

Ps.32.1 · **for** · genre: psalm

Key term. אֲשֶׁר יוֹסֵף עֲשָׂיוֹשָׁן יִרְשָׁא; ashre H835; nasa H5375 Qal passive participle; pesha H6588; kasah H3680 Qal passive participle; chataah H2401

Force. 'Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered.' David's blessing, cited by Paul in Rom 4:7-8 as the negative counterpart to the reckoning of righteousness. Nasa ('lifted away', of the transgression) and kasah ('covered', of the sin) describe what God does with sin when reckoning righteousness. The Hebrew imagery is non-imputation of guilt rather than transformation of the sinner

Ps.32.2 · **for** · genre: psalm

Key term. וְיִהְיֶה לְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ בְּשָׁחַד; ashre H835; chashav H2803 Qal imperfect 3ms with negation; YHWH H3068; avon H5771

Force. 'Blessed is the man against whom YHWH does not count iniquity.' Chashav H2803 in the negative: YHWH does not credit/reckon iniquity to the blessed person. The same Hebrew verb used positively in Gen 15:6 (chashav righteousness to Abraham) used negatively here (not chashav iniquity to David). Paul quotes this verse in Rom 4:8 as the OT precedent for the non-reckoning of sin paired with the reckoning of righteousness

Tit.3.5 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων τῶν ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ ἃ ἐποιήσαμεν ἡμεῖς ἀλλὰ κατὰ τὸ αὐτοῦ ἔλεος ἔσωσεν ἡμᾶς; ergon G2041; dikaiosyne G1343; poieō G4160; eleos G1656; sōzō G4982 aorist active indicative 3s

Force. 'He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy.' The clause ouk ex ergon ton en dikaiosyne ha epoiesamen hemeis ('not from works of righteousness which WE performed') is the strongest Pauline denial of works-righteousness as the ground of salvation. Mercy (eleos) and grace (charis, v.7) replace personal works. Confirms that the believer's standing is not grounded in righteousness inherent in or produced by the believer

Rom.10.3 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀγνοοῦντες γὰρ τὴν τοῦ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην καὶ τὴν ἰδίαν ζητοῦντες στήσαι τῇ δικαιοσύνῃ τοῦ θεοῦ οὐχ ὑπετάγησαν; agnoeō G50; dikaiosyne G1343; idios G2398; zēteō G2212; histēmi G2476; hypotassō G5293

Force. 'Being ignorant of the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking to establish their own, they did not submit to God's righteousness.' Sharp contrast between he tou theou dikaiosyne (the righteousness from God, external source) and ten idian (their own, internal source). The implicit accusation is that seeking to establish a personal righteousness is the failure mode, while submitting to God's righteousness is the submission of faith. Direct lexical confirmation of the Phil 3:9 contrast

Concordance lemmas traversed

G3049, G1343, G1344, G1342, G4100, G4102, G2041, G2038, G1431, G1435, G5485, G4982, G2983, G2525, G5218, G266, G765, G4160, G1096, G1097, G2316, G5547, G3173, G2476, G2398, G2212, G50, G5293, G1656, G3551, G1537, G1722, G846, G3956, G5565, G3439, G1699, G1909, G1223, G3195, H2803, H6666, H6664, H539, H3068, H835, H5375, H6588, H3680, H2401, H5771, H3847, H899, H3468, H4598, H5844, H2931, H5708

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, On the Spirit and the Letter (NPNF1-05); Chrysostom, Homilies on Romans (NPNF1-11); Clement of Rome, 1 Clement 32 · **complicates** · **unverified**

"Augustine teaches that righteousness is the gracious gift of God through faith, but largely uses the language of internal transformation by grace rather than the precise Reformed forensic vocabulary. 1 Clement 32: 'we are not justified by ourselves but by faith'"

catholic_magisterial · Council of Trent Session 6, Decree on Justification (1547); Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 1987-1995 (vatican.va) · complicates · verified

“CCC 1989: 'Justification is not only the remission of sins, but also the sanctification and renewal of the interior man.' Trent rejects forensic-only imputation in favor of infused righteousness; affirms grounding in Christ”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article IV on Justification (1530); Formula of Concord Epitome III (1577) (bookofconcord.org) · affirms · verified

“Formula of Concord Epitome III: God 'imputes to us the righteousness of Christ's obedience, on account of which righteousness we are received into grace by God, and regarded as righteous”

anglican · 39 Articles of Religion, Article XI Of the Justification of Man (churchofengland.org); cross-referenced to the Homily of Justification · affirms · verified

“Article XI: 'We are accounted righteous before God, only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ by Faith, and not for our own works or deservings. Wherefore, that we are justified by Faith only, is a most wholesome Doctrine”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 11.1-3; Heidelberg Catechism Q60-61; Belgic Confession Article 23; Canons of Dort 2.5 · affirms · unverified

“WCF 11.1: God justifies 'not by infusing righteousness into them, but by pardoning their sins, and by accounting and accepting their persons as righteous; not for any thing wrought in them, but for Christ's sake alone”

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article IX Of the Justification of Man (umc.org); Wesley sermon Justification by Faith · affirms · verified

“Article IX: 'We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings.' Wesleyan stress on imparted righteousness in sanctification follows justification”

anabaptist · Schleithem Confession (1527, silent on justification mechanism); Dordrecht Confession (1632) Articles 4-6 on Christ's coming and the gospel · complicates · unverified

“Anabaptist mainstream affirms salvation by faith in Christ's work, but historically focused on discipleship and the visible church rather than on the precise forensic-versus-infused mechanism debated between Catholics and Reformers”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths Truth 5 The Salvation of Man (ag.org) · affirms · unverified

“AG Truth 5: 'Man's only hope of redemption is through the shed blood of Jesus Christ the Son of God.' Affirms justification by faith in Christ's work; does not arbitrate the forensic-versus-infused debate”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America, The Orthodox Faith Volume IV Spirituality (oca.org); patristic synthesis on theosis (Athanasius On the Incarnation, Maximus the Confessor) · complicates · unverified

“Orthodoxy treats Reformation justification debate as Western legal-judicial framing. Salvation described as theosis, participation in divine life through union with Christ, not as a forensic transaction in a courtroom”

catholic_magisterial · Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification (1999), Catholic Church and Lutheran World Federation (vatican.va) · complicates · unverified

“JDDJ 15: 'By grace alone, in faith in Christ's saving work and not because of any merit on our part, we are accepted by God and receive the Holy Spirit.' Imputation and infusion language reached qualified ecumenical convergence”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/4.htm>

“Romans 4 repeatedly uses *logizomai* G3049 ('to reckon, count, credit, impute') with *eis dikaiosynen* G1343 ('as righteousness') at vv.3, 5, 6, 8, 22, 23, 24, citing Gen 15:6 LXX as the load-bearing pattern”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/15-6.htm>

“Gen 15:6 *chashav* H2803 ('to think, calculate, reckon, impute') *Qal wayyiqtol*, plus *tsedaqah* H6666 ('righteousness'). God's action of crediting righteousness to Abraham rested on Abraham's belief, not on Abraham's works”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_corinthians/5-21.htm

“2 Cor 5:21 'he made him who knew no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God'. Two parallel non-natural attributions structured by *hyper hemon* and *en autoi*”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/3-9.htm>

“Phil 3:9 contrasts *emen dikaiosynen ten ek nomou* (mine, from law) with *dikaosynen ek theou* (from God) through *dia pisteos Christou*. The source of righteousness is outside the believer”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/5-19.htm>

“Rom 5:19 *kathistemi* G2525 future passive: by the obedience of the one (Christ) the many will be constituted righteous. Representative-imputation logic parallel to the Adam-disobedience clause”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/jeremiah/23-6.htm>

“Jer 23:6 *YHWH Tsidkenu* ('YHWH our righteousness'). *Tsedeq* H6664 in masculine singular construct plus first person plural suffix. The Messianic king bears the divine name as the righteousness of the covenant people”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/james/2-23.htm>

“James 2:23 cites Gen 15:6 in identical Greek wording to Paul (*logizomai eis dikaiosynen*) but applies it in the works-vindication frame. Resolves by two-frame reading: God's verdict versus the witness stand”

complicates · category: magisterial · https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P6Y.HTM

“CCC 1989: Justification is not only the remission of sins, but also the sanctification and renewal of the interior man. CCC 1991: faith, hope, and charity are poured into our hearts”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/epitome/righteousness-of-faith/>

“Formula of Concord Epitome III: God forgives our sins out of pure grace, without any work, merit, or worthiness of ours, and imputes to us the righteousness of Christ's obedience”

supports · category: tradition_primary · https://anglicansonline.org/basics/thirty-nine_articles.html

“39 Articles, Article XI: We are accounted righteous before God, only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ by Faith, and not for our own works or deservings”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“UMC Article IX: We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- confession-tradition-divergence
- k2-explicitly-excluded-cluster-a